

BERGEN, NORWAY

This illustration of a view of the landscape at Bergen, where Grieg was born and grew up, is from the great composer's own sketchbook.

A decisive move

Grieg's decision to move to Copenhagen was significant. The city was the cultural hub of both Denmark and Norway. Before 1814, Norway was part of the Kingdom of Denmark. After this, it entered into a political union with Sweden that lasted until 1905, although the Danish influence still remained strong. Danish, for example, was the standard written language in Norway for much of the 19th century and even the country's capital, Christiania (later Oslo), was named after a Danish king. However, attitudes were beginning to change. The growth of a Romantic nationalist movement led many Norwegians to try to formulate a distinctive cultural identity for their country. This trend affected all major branches of the arts—music, literature, and art.

“ [Like] eating a **pink bonbon** stuffed with **snow.** ”

CLAUDE DEBUSSY, ON LISTENING TO GRIEG'S
MUSIC

In music, there were attempts to rediscover and refine the old folk songs and dances that had survived in the countryside. Grieg's interest in this was sparked by his friendship with Rikard